THE ARCHITECT, THE ORCHESTRATOR, AND THE APPRENTICE: RETHINKING WORK IN THE AGE OF AI AND AGENTS



PAUL ROETZER

Founder & CEO

SmarterX & Marketing AI Institute

MAICON FORWARD

#MAICON26

Think back to your first job out of school.

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I learned resilience, patience, and how to work through the process of doing hard things.

I took a lot of notes, I read, I observed,
and I was given room to experiment.

My time generated revenue for the firm, and prepared me to take on more responsibility early in my career.

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Everything I did back then can be done by AI today
for $20/month. Better, faster, and cheaper.

There was no “easy” button for writing, design, problem-solving, and decision-making. You did the work.

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The process was the point.

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The Evolution of Entry-Level Work

The Future of Work Hypothesis

AI model advancements and agent capabilities will force a radical transformation of talent, teams, and organizational structures.

Leaders face conflicting pressures to take a responsible, human-centered approach to AI adoption, while leveraging AI for near-term gains in efficiency, productivity, creativity, and profitability.

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As AI transforms the workplace, it is doing far more than automating tasks.

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AI systems are redefining expertise, reshaping organizational structures, and changing how professionals learn, contribute, and advance.

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Historically, junior employees did the tactical work.

Over time, they built the experience and judgment required to manage and lead other producers.

But, as AI systems take on more of that foundational work,
the traditional ladder from novice to expert begins to break.

The Fundamental Question

If AI does the work people once learned from, how will organizations develop future managers, experts, and executives?

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Human-Centered Change

If I was trying to build an automated organization or team, this would be a very different talk.

OpenAI

OpenAI Imagines Our AI Future

Stages of Artificial Intelligence

Level 1	Chatbots, AI with conversational language
Level 2	Reasoners, human-level problem solving
Level 3	Agents, systems that can take actions
Level 4	Innovators, AI that can aid in invention
Level 5	Organizations, AI that can do the work of an organization

Source: Bloomberg reporting

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Source: Bloomberg

AI-forward = people first

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"In the process of making software more intelligent, AI has the potential to make brands more human by enabling us to focus increased time and energy on communications, creativity, culture, community, and the human condition.

"AI should make us better people, professionals, and organizations. However, this will not happen without a continuous focus on the responsible application of AI across all business functions."

Source: Marketing AI Institute

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“We believe in a human-centered approach to AI that empowers and augments professionals. AI technologies should be assistive, not autonomous.”

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“We believe that humans remain accountable for all decisions and actions, even when assisted by AI. The human must remain in the loop in all AI applications.”

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“We believe in the importance of upskilling and reskilling professionals, and using AI to build more fulfilling careers and lives.”

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The goal is to maximize the benefit to people,
not just generate greater profits.

Grow companies. Grow careers.

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I want to hire as many humans as I can, but never more than I need.

100 person companies doing the work of 1,000 (or 10,000) person companies.

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Revenue per employee of $250,000 becomes $2.5M (or $25M).

The Scientist and The Apprentice

The ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE Show

With Paul Roetzer and Mike Kaput

Episode 165

AI Replacing Young Workers, AI Industry Gets Political, Google's "Nano Banana," ChatGPT Parental Controls & Anthropic Settles Author Lawsuit

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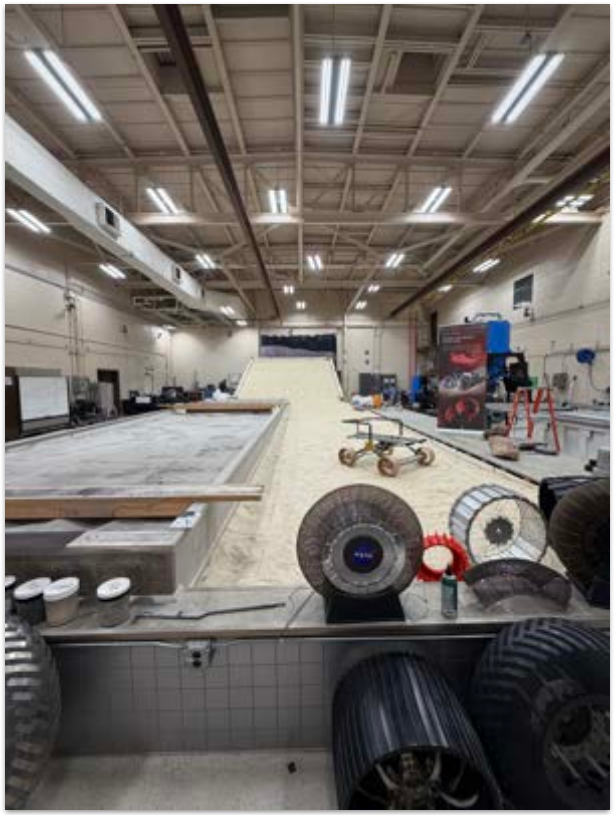
"So we don't need to hire associates anymore?"

2026

MARKETING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE INSTITUTE | SMARTERX

Marketing Talent
AI IMPACT REPORT


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You Mar 13, 4:51 PM (Edited)



Had some inspiration today. I think this is a really important concept that could be key to the future of work.

I turned it into a MAICON keynote abstract to start. Lots more to it, but this gives you the basic idea.

Thoughts?

The Orchestrator and The Apprentice: Rethinking Work in the Age of AI and Agents

AI is not just changing how work gets done. It is changing who creates value, how expertise is built, and what it means to be a professional.

As intelligent agents take on more of the tasks once handled by analysts, associates, coordinators, and assistants, a new role is emerging: the orchestrator.

These professionals frame the right problems, direct workflows across humans and machines, and apply the judgment needed to turn AI outputs into action.

At the same time, organizations face a critical challenge: if AI takes over the work people used to learn from, how do we develop the next generation of professionals and leaders?

In this keynote, Paul Roetzer introduces a new framework for the future of work built around two defining roles: the orchestrator and the apprentice.

He explores how AI and agents are reshaping knowledge work, why apprenticeship may become more essential in the age of automation, and what leaders must do now to build smarter organizations and stronger talent pipelines.

3 replies ✨ Summarize 🔥 4 💙 1

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We don’t know what the real impact on entry-level work will be, or how quickly it will happen across different industries.

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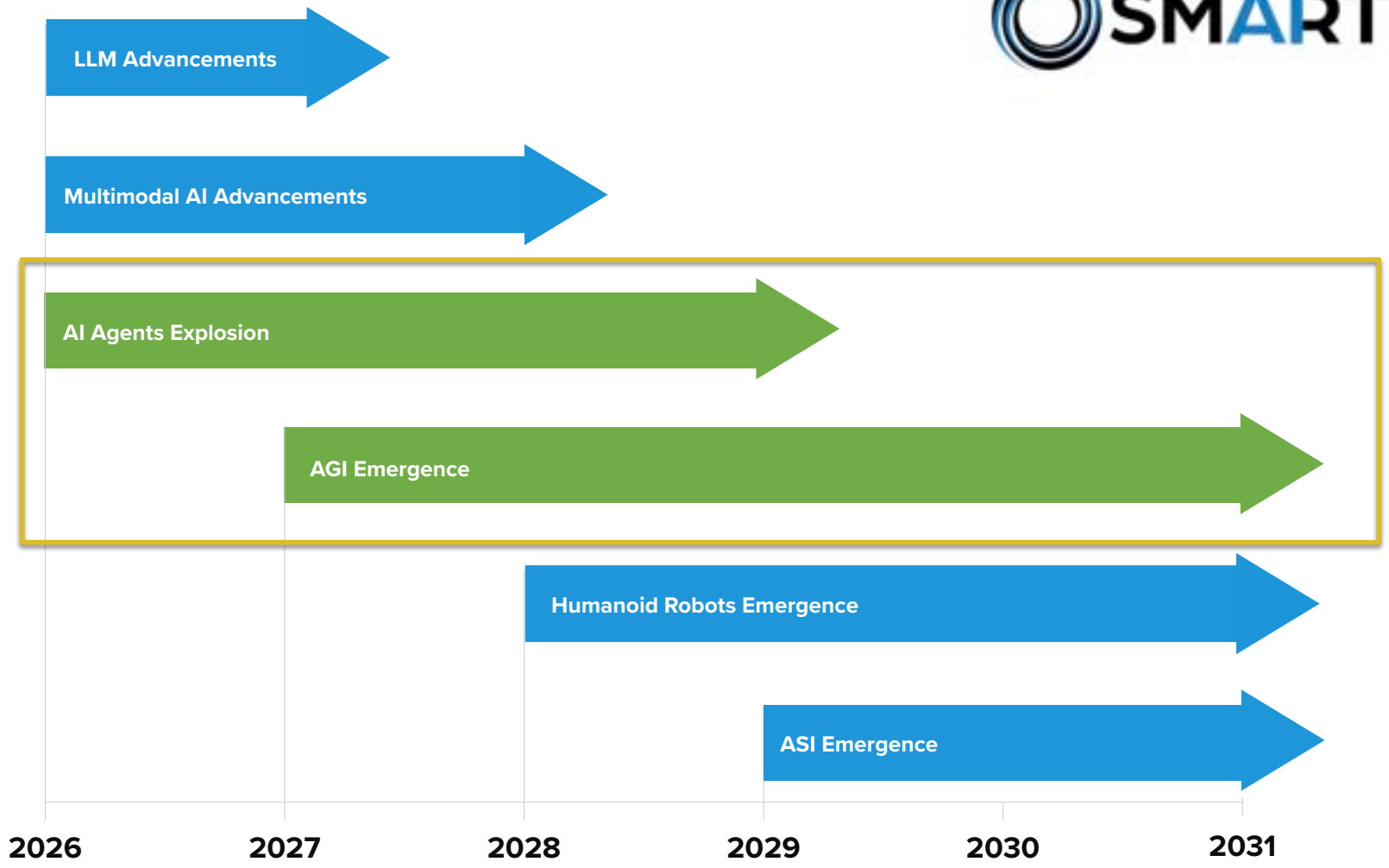
My goal is not to convince you that The Architect, The Orchestrator, and The Apprentice is the right framework.

My goal is to convince you that the traditional framework is becoming obsolete and that we need to ask hard questions about the future.

- How will current roles evolve?
- What new roles will emerge?
- What skills and traits will remain uniquely human?
- How will AI agents transform workflows and org charts?
- How will middle management be impacted?
- How will the role of entry-level employees change?

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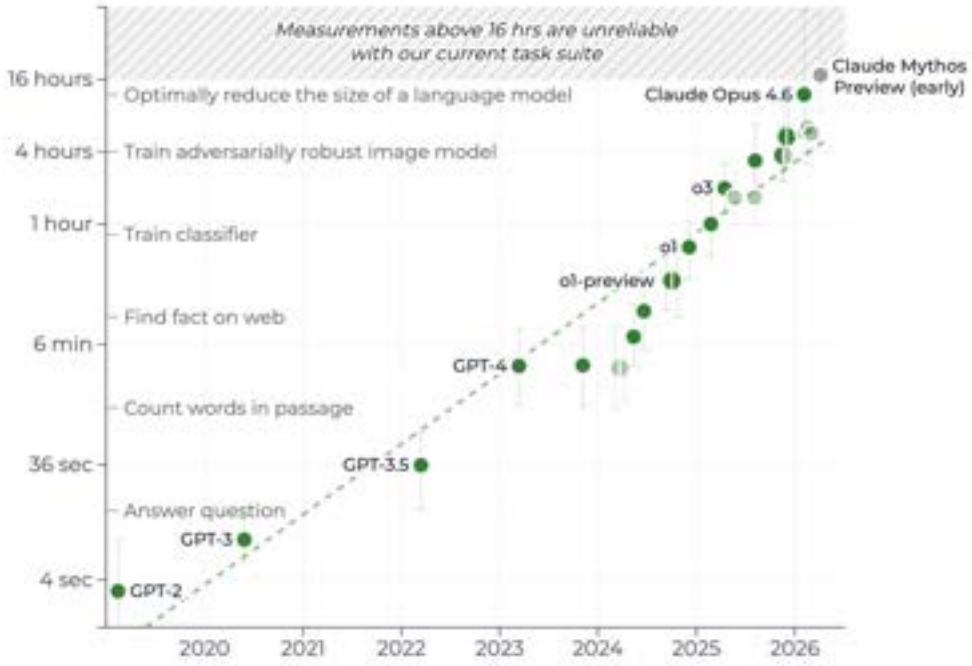
The Coming Shift



SOURCE: COPYRIGHT 2026 SMARTERX VENTURES, LLC · V3.0 · UPDATED 4-29-26

The AI labs will continue to accelerate progress toward AGI and beyond.

AI will get smarter, more generally capable, and more reliable at completing long-horizon tasks.



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Some work (maybe the majority) will be automated by agents.

Work will compress.

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Teams will consist of humans and agents.

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We need fewer humans doing the same amount of work.

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Productivity will increase, but management's capacity to review and approve work will be a blocker.

Roles will evolve faster than previous revolutions.

New roles will emerge, but it's not clear how those will be safe from automation.

Human-in-the-lead vs human-in-the-loop will be a friction point for organizations that want to move fast and disrupt.

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Human-to-Machine (H2M) Scale™



Level 0

All Human

All human, all the time.
The system does not use any AI and is only capable of doing what it has been instructed to do. All automation is manual.



Level 1

Mostly Human

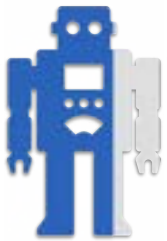
Limited intelligent automation.
The system uses AI in certain aspects, but it is largely reliant on human inputs and oversight.



Level 2

Half & Half

Half human, half machine.
The system can manage most aspects of the use case, but still requires human inputs and oversight.



Level 3

Mostly Machine

Predominantly AI powered.
The system can operate without human inputs or oversight in select conditions.



Level 4

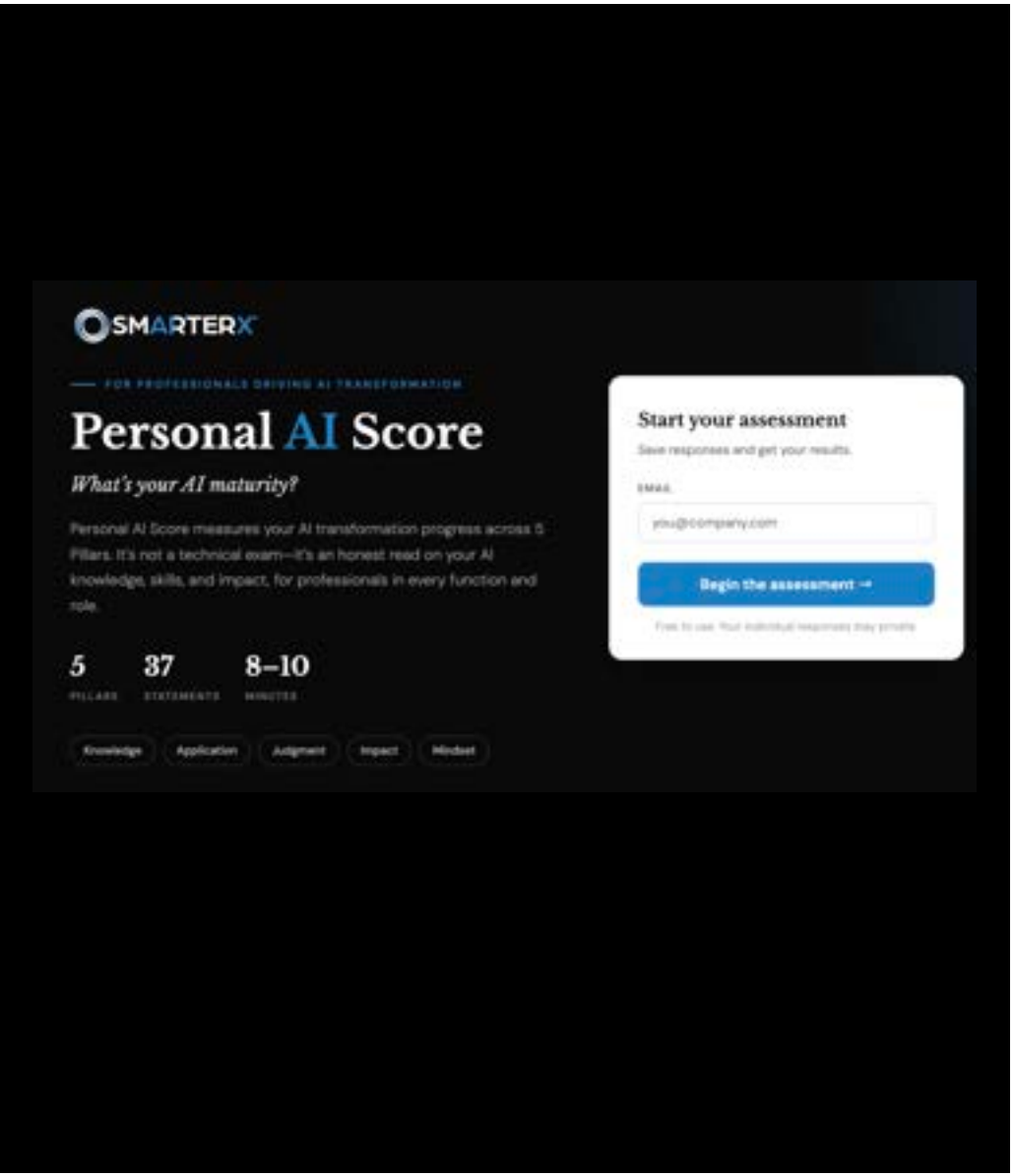
All Machine

Full autonomy.
The system can perform at or above human level without inputs or oversight. The human simply defines the desired outcome, and the machine does all the work.

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The skills, traits, behaviors, and mindsets of employees will have to adapt.

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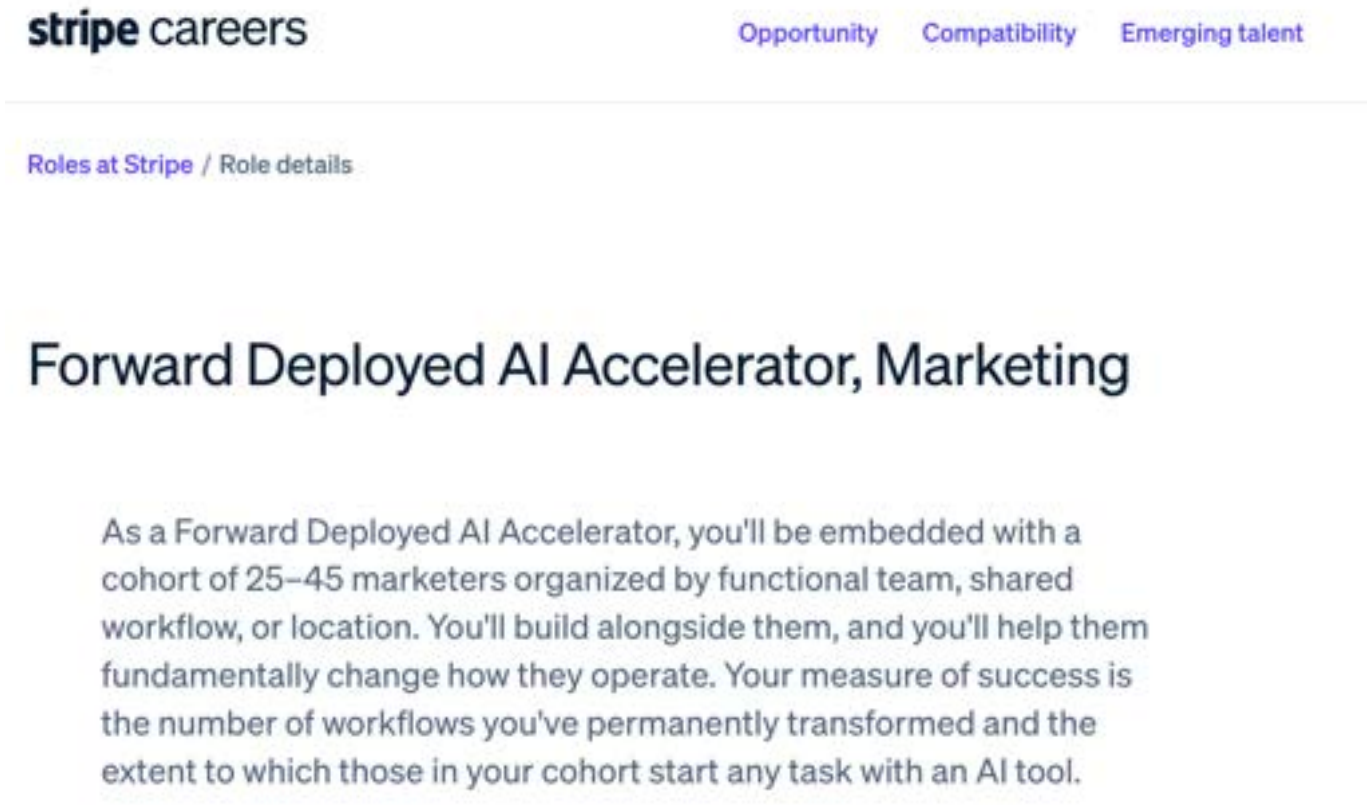
Available in public beta.

The Structure of Teams: A Theoretical Model

The Architect: Designs the Systems

This role defines the strategies, workflows, governance, team structures, and human-machine operating models that make AI useful, scalable, and aligned.

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Source: Stripe (accessed 10-6-26)

What You'll Do

- Identify and document the highest-leverage workflow transformations within your cohort's day-to-day work by deeply understanding their processes and outputs
- Build custom tools, agents, automations, and skills tailored to each marketer's specific responsibilities
- Coach and partner with each marketer through a progressive journey — from awareness, to first win, to regular AI integration, to full workflow transformation, to self-sufficiency
- Teach marketers to build and iterate on their own tools over time, creating independence
- Recognize patterns across your cohort and systematically scale what works — a tool built for one marketer will be reusable for their peers
- Document every tool, playbook, and transformation pattern you build so the entire FDA team uses each other's work
- Share wins visibly within your cohort and with leadership to build momentum, inspire, and celebrate success
- Track individual and cohort progress rigorously against a defined maturity model, moving every marketer toward self-sustaining, AI-first work
- Prepare marketers for an agentic future — not just prompt writing, but designing, building, and overseeing autonomous, multi-agent workflows

Who You Are

- You are a deep AI practitioner. You build agents, automations, and tools fluently. You don't just know what AI can do in theory. You've built things that changed how real teams operate, and the people you built for actually use what you shipped. You build in real time alongside the people you support.
- You spot transformation opportunities and execute on them. You look at a team's workflows and see where AI changes the economics: where existing work can be done in a fraction of the time, or where entirely new programs become viable that weren't worth doing before. Then you build the thing, not just the slide.
- You understand marketing work. You either have direct experience in marketing or quickly learn the workflows, deliverables, tools, and pressures of your assigned cohort. You know that understanding someone's work is a prerequisite to transforming it.
- You are a pattern recognizer. When you build something that works for one person, you immediately see how it applies to others. You think in systems, not one-off solutions.
- You are a strong communicator. You explain technical concepts clearly to non-technical audiences, adapt your style to different people, and make progress visible to leadership and stakeholders.
- You are high-caliber, persistent, and versatile. Your skills and experience are valuable across the company. You're the kind of person who succeeds in many roles at Stripe.
- You bias toward action and speed. You'd rather show someone a working proof-of-concept on their own deliverable today than present a polished deck about what's theoretically possible next quarter.
- You are comfortable with ambiguity and evolution. This is a new team building a new operating model. The playbook will be rewritten as we learn. You thrive in that environment.

The Orchestrator: Runs the Systems

This role directs AI agents and human collaborators, evaluates outputs, optimizes workflows, and turns intelligence into decisions and actions.

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Orchestrator Skills

- Applying responsible AI principles
- Choosing the right AI tools, agents, and models
- Connecting and managing data sources
- Controlling token budgets and AI system access
- Guiding AI systems and teams to produce outputs
- Evaluating the quality and reliability of AI outputs
- Managing human-in-loop vs human-in-the-lead processes
- Overseeing and governing agent workflows
- Reviewing and approving work products

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The Apprentice: Learns within the Systems

This role develops judgment and expertise through observation and experimentation in a world where much of the entry-level work is absorbed by AI.

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The traditional entry-level path served two purposes at once. It created leverage for the firm, and it trained the next generation.

The tasks were inefficient, but they were how people learned.

Raw production is no longer the valued contribution.

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In an AI-forward marketing department, much of the production layer gets compressed.

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The marketing apprentice learns by observing, directing, evaluating, and refining AI-assisted work while gaining exposure to strategic judgment.

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In the apprentice model, we focus on teaching AI literacy, judgment, context, taste, ethics, institutional knowledge, interpersonal communications, and emotional intelligence (EQ).

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Apprentice Needs

- Shadowing and mentorship
- Frameworks for evaluating AI-assisted work
- Dynamic learning as the AI systems advance
- Personalized experiences that build toward mastery
- Freedom to experiment without ROI mandates
- Exposure to problem-solving and decision-making
- Visibility into chain-of-thought (from AI and senior staff)

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Apprentice Skills

- Analyzing AI chain-of-thought
- Asking the right questions
- Assessing AI outputs
- Collaborating with AI assistants
- Exercising judgment
- Identifying use cases
- Optimizing workflows
- Orchestrating AI agents

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These are best learned through proximity, repetition, feedback, and experimentation.

The organizations that operationalize this gain an advantage.

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Traditional Model

- Affordable labor
- Leverage productivity for profits
- Learn by doing the tactical work
- Develop abilities to manage & lead future producers

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Apprentice Model

- Investment in future value
- Leverage profits to create career paths
- Learn by observing humans and collaborating with AI
- Develop abilities to architect and orchestrate work

We can accelerate the expertise and impact of entry-level workers through apprenticeships.

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We have to be more open.

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Source: Tobi Lutke, X (May 9, 2026)

"The risk is not that AI does the work. The risk is that AI does the work and we never learn from it. If every interaction with an agent happens in a private window, the only person who learns anything is the person at the keyboard. Everyone else is locked out of the apprenticeship. . . . "

"The right model is not human or machine. It is the apprentice and the master, both watching each other learn, both getting better on the shop floor."

We have to have a vision for the future of work.

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Sample Draft: The AI-Forward CEO Memo

Subject: Our AI-Forward Future: A Commitment to People, Performance, and Possibility

Team,

We are living through a period of unprecedented technological change. The advancements in artificial intelligence are not just another trend; they are forcing a radical transformation of every industry and job function.

As AI assistants and AI agents from leading technology companies continue to grow smarter and more capable, we have to adapt to integrate those capabilities into our jobs.

Every business has the opportunity to disrupt, and faces increasing risks of being disrupted.

Standing still is not an option. We are choosing to lead, and our path forward is to reimagine what's possible in our organization.

To do this, we are formally committing to being an **AI-forward** organization.

Being AI-forward is a mindset and an operational imperative. It is also a human-centered philosophy that uses AI to accelerate efficiency, productivity, creativity, growth, and innovation, all while prioritizing ethics, transparency, and trust.

Our goal is to build a smarter, more intelligent, and more human company.

This is more than a vision. It is backed by a plan. Effective immediately, we are committing to five foundational pillars to guide our transformation:

1. **Launch an Internal AI Academy:** Education is the starting point. We will provide comprehensive training to accelerate AI literacy for everyone.
2. **Create an AI Council:** A cross-functional team will be charged with developing our AI policies and practices, ensuring a cohesive and responsible approach across the organization.
3. **Develop Responsible AI Principles and Generative AI Policies:** We will establish clear guidelines to ensure our use of AI is ethical, transparent, and aligned with our values.
4. **Conduct AI Impact Assessments:** We will systematically evaluate how smarter and more powerful AI models will impact our people, products and services, customers, partners, workflows, vendors, and industry.
5. **Build an AI Roadmap:** We will develop a dynamic strategic roadmap to prioritize AI use

cases and projects, and infuse AI capabilities across the entire business.

What This Means for You

This transformation requires a commitment from every employee.

AI understanding and usage is a **baseline expectation of everyone at our company**. This is not optional. We will build the future of this company around AI-forward professionals who embrace AI, adhere to our responsible AI principles, and apply AI to drive performance and change.

We are empowering you with the tools and training you need to succeed.

I expect you to be curious, to experiment, and to actively seek ways to integrate AI into your daily tasks and workflows. And I ask that you share your experiences and insights with your peers to support and inspire one another.

Success will require a "growth mindset" in which AI is seen as a catalyst for continuous change. This involves ongoing experimentation with new workflows, a willingness to "fail fast" and learn from those attempts, and the ambition to pursue stretch goals that push us beyond our comfort zones.

Before teams request additional headcount or resources, they must first demonstrate why their objectives cannot be achieved using AI. This applies to all of us, including me and the entire executive team.

As AI becomes more integrated into our work, our roles will naturally evolve. Some current tasks will be fully automated, freeing us to focus on higher-value work. While there is a possibility that some jobs may dramatically change, or even go away, new jobs will emerge as well.

As we navigate this ever-evolving business landscape and economy, we are committed to investing in our people, providing the reskilling and upskilling necessary to prepare you for the future of work.

We have an incredible opportunity to reimagine our business model, reinvent our careers, and redefine what's possible. I am confident that by embracing an AI-forward, people-first approach, we will thrive through this disruption and lead the way.

Let's build the future, together.

Regards,

[CEO Name & Signature]

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A Thought Experiment: The Future of Work

1. Everyone has access to a Gen AI platform (ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini) that can think, reason, understand, and create.

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2. Everyone understands what AI is, and what it is capable of doing.

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6. Everyone's AI assistants have on-demand access to a comprehensive company knowledge base and clean, real-time data.

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5. Everyone has on-demand access to high-level strategic support and consultation from their AI for any business problem or goal.
6. Everyone's AI assistants have on-demand access to a comprehensive company knowledge base and clean, real-time data.
7. Everyone has access to AI agents that can complete digital tasks with high-levels of reliability and autonomy.

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We have to invest in the next generation of marketers.

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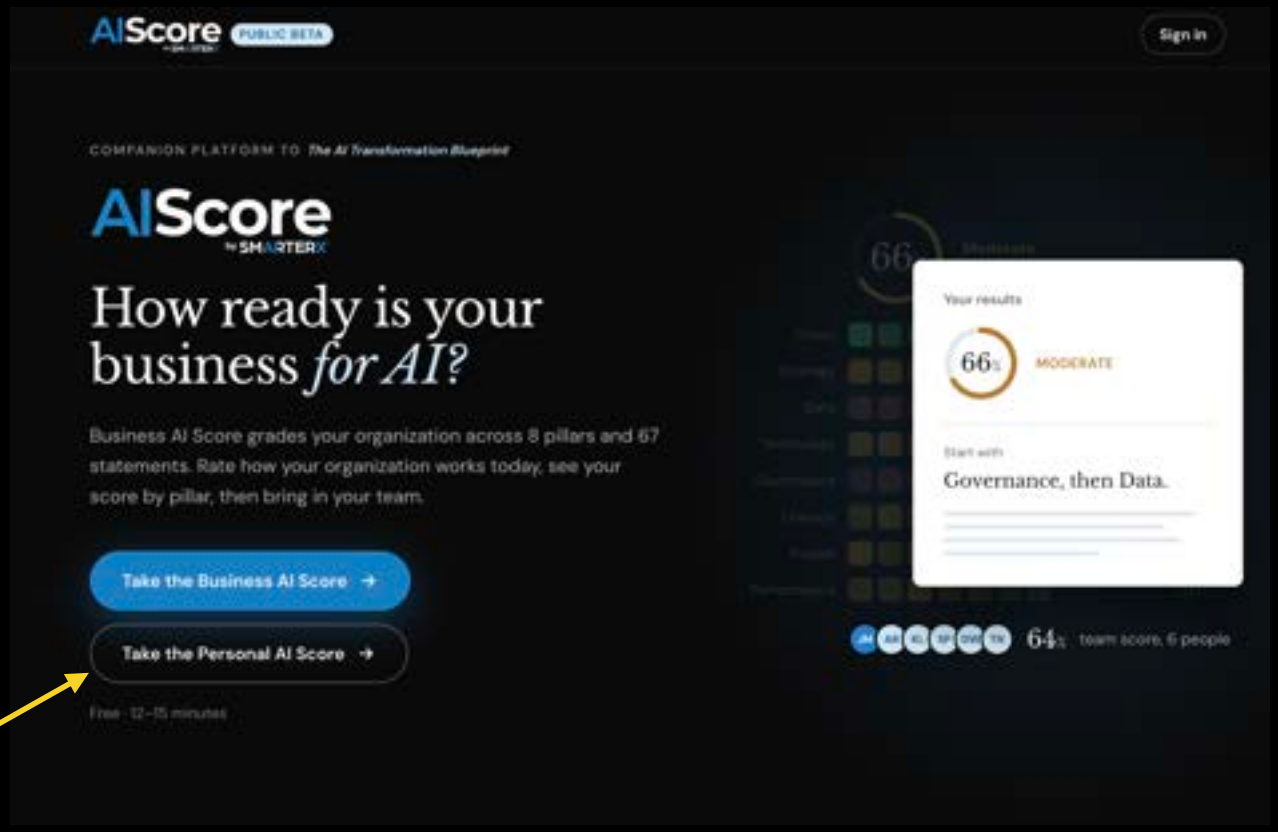
What's Next?

Think about the next generation of marketers over the coming two days at MAICON.

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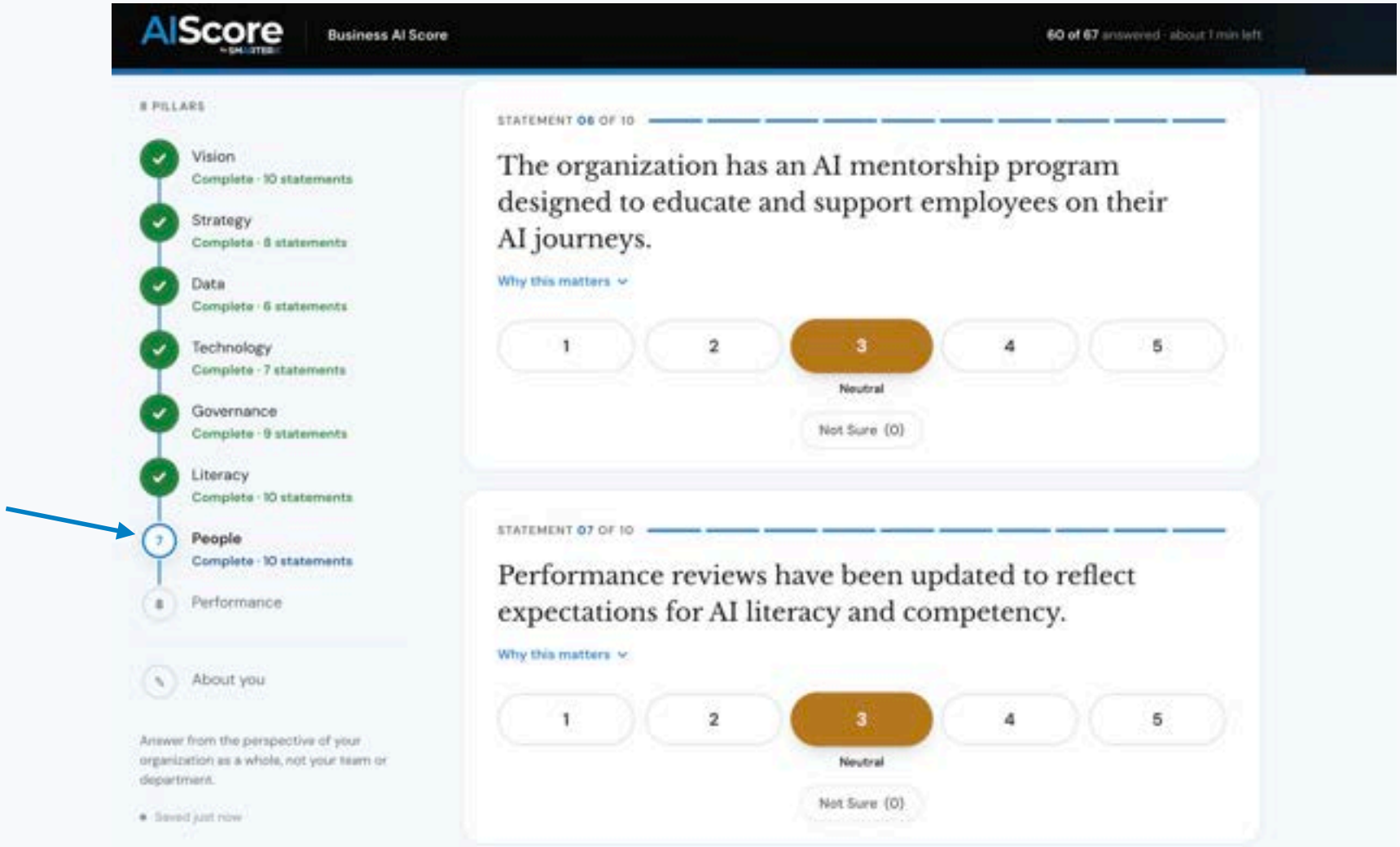
Consider how the roles will evolve, and what we can do as leaders to create opportunities and prepare them for the future of work.

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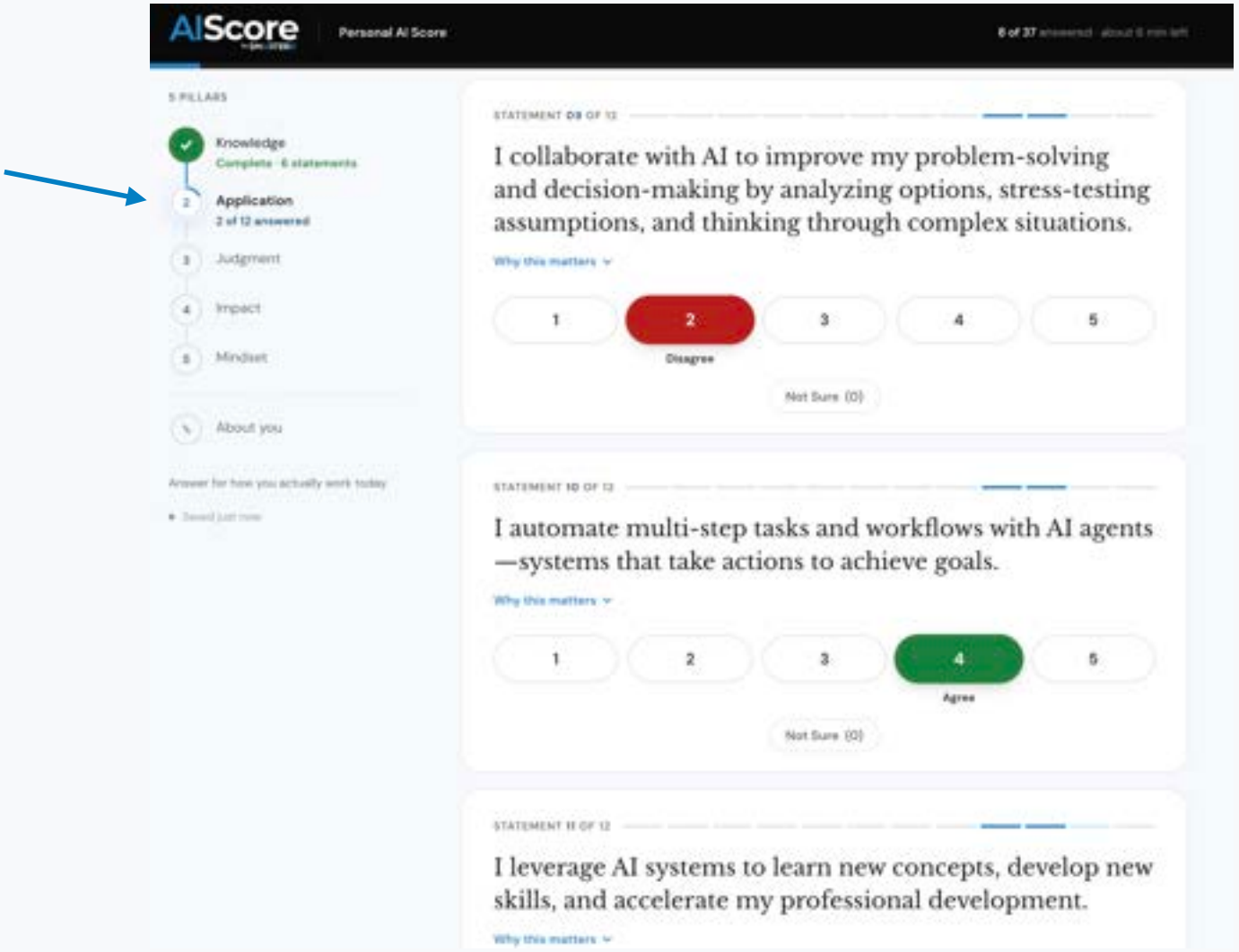
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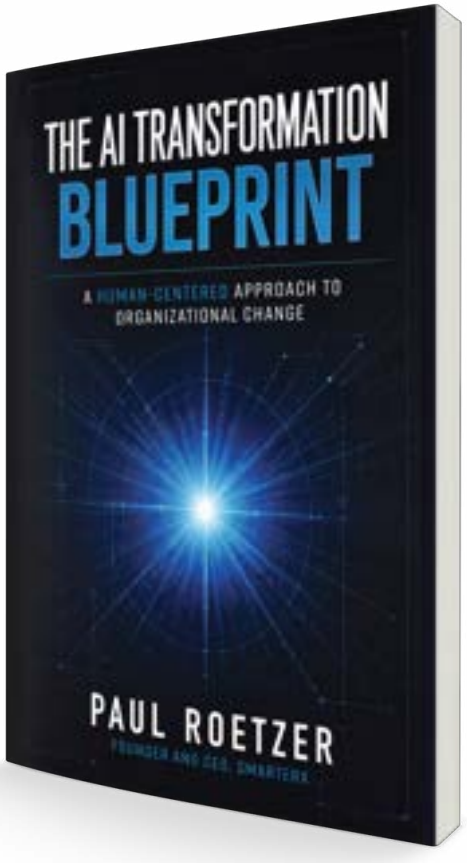
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A change management guide for leaders who want to move with urgency, clarity, and humanity.



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Jobs will change.

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Some jobs will go away.

New jobs and career paths will emerge.

Choose to learn, grow, and evolve.

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Be willing to inspire and mentor others to do the same.


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Founder & CEO
SmarterX & Marketing AI Institute
THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.
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